

TIMELINE 1865-1877

Reconstruction ■ First “black codes” ■ **Thirteenth Amendment** ■ Civil Rights Act ■ Formation of Ku Klux Klan ■ **Fourteenth Amendment** ■ Impeachment of President Johnson ■ **Fifteenth Amendment** ■ Grant administration ■ **End of Reconstruction**

“The question now is, do you mean to **make good to us** the promises in your Constitution?”

FREDERICK DOUGLASS ADDRESSING THE 1876 REPUBLICAN CONVENTION

1865	1866	1867	1868	1869	1870	1871	1872-73	1874-75	1876-77
	FEBRUARY Congress passes a law extending the powers of the Freedmen's Bureau to ensure that the formerly enslaved are treated fairly. President Johnson later vetoes the measure, but Congress overrides his veto.	MAY Six Confederate veterans form an organization called the Ku Klux Klan in Pulaski, Tennessee. Initially a social club, it will become the largest of various vigilante groups using terrorist methods to limit Black rights.	MARCH Arkansas is admitted to the Union, becoming the 37th state.	JULY Congress passes new Reconstruction laws increasing the powers of the military governors in the South. They are known as the "Reconstruction Acts."	FEBRUARY Congress proposes a Fifteenth Amendment to guarantee the rights of all citizens to vote, regardless of "race, color, or previous condition of servitude." At this date only a minority of states, North or South, allow Black people to vote.	FEBRUARY The Fifteenth Amendment is ratified, but Black people are still widely denied the right to vote by such means as tax, property, or literacy tests. Mississippi is readmitted to the Union.	FEBRUARY Congress passes a second Ku Klux Klan Act.	MAY 1872 The Republican Party splits. A new Liberal Republican group nominates Horace Greeley as its presidential candidate. They call for honest government and an end to military intervention in the South.	NOVEMBER 1874 Democrats win a majority in the House of Representatives. Republicanism is in decline. Democrats are in charge of state legislatures in seven former Confederate states.
MAY With most Confederate forces having surrendered, President Andrew Johnson issues a general amnesty to all "rebels," other than senior Confederate officers and officials.		JUNE Congress adopts the Fourteenth Amendment to the U.S. Constitution. It extends citizenship to Black people and limits the Congressional representation of any state that does not allow them to vote.		MARCH President Johnson's bid in the Senate begins. Johnson is narrowly defeated in May, but will be a lame duck for the remainder of his term.	MARCH Ulysses S. Grant is inaugurated as president. He will be a father, peace president, and, though personally honest, will be badly let down by the corruption of many of his appointees.		MAY 1872 Congress passes an Amnesty Act allowing most former Confederates to seek public office.	MARCH 1875 Congress passes a Civil Rights Act giving all citizens equal access to public facilities, such as hotels and transportation. The Supreme Court will declare this unconstitutional in 1883.	
JUNE President Johnson appoints governors for six former Confederate states and restores Tennessee to the Union.		NOVEMBER Republican supporters of the Fourteenth Amendment win a landslide victory in Congressional elections. They have radical Reconstruction plans despite the president's opposition.	AUGUST With Congress out of session, President Johnson appoints Secretary of War Edwin Stanton a Radical Republican, from office. This is contrary to the "Tenure of Office Act," which Johnson believes to be unconstitutional.	MAY North America's first transcontinental railroad is completed in a ceremony held at Promontory Point, Utah.	MAY Congress passes a law to enforce a "Ku Klux Klan" or Enforcement Act in an attempt to limit intimidation of prospective Black voters.	APRIL Congress passes a law to enforce a "Ku Klux Klan" or Enforcement Act in an attempt to limit intimidation of prospective Black voters.	APRIL Congress passes a law to enforce a "Ku Klux Klan" or Enforcement Act in an attempt to limit intimidation of prospective Black voters.	NOVEMBER 1875 The Democrats win a landslide victory in state elections after a decade of Republican rule. Prospective Black voters are challenged by the validity of the Reconstruction process. Southern states are given the right to elect the Republican governor to ensure a free election.	NOVEMBER 1876 The presidential election is held. It is a very close race, but the Republicans win. The Supreme Court will declare this unconstitutional in 1883.
NOVEMBER Mississippi enacts laws to establish the first "Black Codes." These laws limit labor, vagrancy, and similar issues, and are designed to restrict the rights of those who had been enslaved.	APRIL Congress passes a Civil Rights Act, over-riding President Johnson's veto, declaring Black people to be citizens entitled to equal protection under the laws.	NOVEMBER Former Union soldiers establish the Grand Army of the Republic. This veterans' organization will develop considerable political influence.	MARCH Congress also passes the Tenure of Office Act. This limits the president's ability to dismiss Reconstruction measures by changing officials whose appointment originally required approval by the Senate.	OCTOBER Democrats regain control of the state legislatures in Virginia and Tennessee, largely halting the Reconstruction process in these states.	JULY Georgia is readmitted to the Union. All former rebel states have now been readmitted.	MAY Georgia is readmitted to the Union. All former rebel states have now been readmitted.		APRIL 1877 The Congress repeals the Black Militia Act, which removed military government from the South.	MARCH 1877 A Congressional commission reveals the disputed presidential election to Hayes, who is inaugurated later in the month.
DECEMBER The Thirteenth Amendment to the U.S. Constitution, abolishing slavery, comes into effect, having been ratified by 27 states.			SEPTEMBER The Georgia state legislature rejects the purchase of Alaska from Russia, but the process will not be completed until 1868 when the House of Representatives approves the necessary payment.	DECEMBER Women are granted the right to vote in the Wyoming Territory, the first area of the United States to make this change.	DECEMBER Congress convenes with representatives from all states present for the first time since 1860.	SEPTEMBER 1873 The Panic of 1873 is triggered by the failure of a major bank, J.P. Morgan & Co., because of problems with its railroad investments. The banking crisis and a major economic depression last for the next five years.	SEPTEMBER 1873 The Panic of 1873 is triggered by the failure of a major bank, J.P. Morgan & Co., because of problems with its railroad investments. The banking crisis and a major economic depression last for the next five years.		

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